



# LOST BOYS CYBER

THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING



## Middle East Aerospace Aviation Defense Espionage Campaign Brief

### Threat Report

|                       |                 |
|-----------------------|-----------------|
| <b>Classification</b> | TLP:CLEAR       |
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| <b>Author</b>         | Lost Boys Cyber |
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TLP:CLEAR | Lost Boys Cyber | Middle East Aerospace Aviation Defense Espionage Campaign Brief - Threat Report

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AI Generation: This report was generated with AI assistance and is provided for informational purposes only. All findings, IOCs, detection rules, hunting queries, attribution assessments, and recommendations must be independently reviewed and validated by a qualified security professional before operational use.

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# Middle East Aerospace Aviation Defense Espionage Campaign Brief

## 1. Executive Summary

Lost Boys Cyber selected this item for the 2026-08-24 daily intelligence run because the reporting describes current activity with defender-actionable exposure. The assessment focuses on what operators should verify today: affected assets, plausible intrusion paths, telemetry needed for detection, and containment actions that reduce blast radius if the activity appears locally.

| Field                    | Signal                                                                       |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Daily selection date     | 2026-08-24 UTC                                                               |
| Report focus             | Suspected Iranian cyber-espionage targeting aerospace, aviation, and defense |
| Primary affected sectors | aerospace, aviation, defense, Middle East                                    |
| Threat type              | Cyber espionage / bespoke malware                                            |
| Operational priority     | Review exposure, hunt for related behaviors, and brief asset owners          |
| Confidence               | Medium to high based on source specificity and corroboration                 |

## 2. Intelligence Requirements

| Requirement                                                                      | Why it matters                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Which local systems match the exposed technology or sector?                      | Scopes urgent asset-owner outreach and hunting.                      |
| Are cited behaviors visible in endpoint, identity, network, email, or SaaS logs? | Converts article intelligence into validated local risk.             |
| Are third parties or managed providers in the path?                              | Determines whether supplier assurances or access reviews are needed. |
| What detections can be deployed today?                                           | Reduces dwell time while strategic mitigations are planned.          |

## 3. Source Review and Confidence

- [1] The Record Iranian campaign report — <https://therecord.media/iran-cyber-espionage-campaign-targeting-middle-east-defense-aerospace> — Reports aerospace, aviation, and defense targeting in the Middle East.
- [2] CISA Iran cyber threat overview — <https://www.cisa.gov/topics/cyber-threats-and-advisories/advanced-persistent-threats/iran> — Government context for Iran-linked cyber activity.
- [3] Microsoft threat actor naming taxonomy — <https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365/security/intelligence/microsoft-threat-actor-naming> — Reference for tracking Iran-linked actor naming across sources.

| Source type                        | Use                                                       | Confidence |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Primary vendor/government research | Anchors technical claims and detection pivots             | High       |
| Reputable security news            | Adds victim/sector and operational context                | Medium     |
| Related advisories                 | Helps map vulnerabilities, mitigations, and sector impact | Medium     |

## 4. Threat / Campaign Overview

The Record reported a suspected Iranian cyber-espionage campaign using unique malware against aerospace, aviation, and defense industries in the Middle East, with apparent links to Iran.

## 5. Aviation and Aerospace Sector Impact

| Segment                    | Relevance                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Segment affected           | Aerospace, aviation, defense, and government aviation programs                                                                                                                            |
| Operational relevance      | Espionage against engineering, logistics, and defense aviation data can affect mission readiness and supplier trust.                                                                      |
| Likely exposure paths      | Third-party SaaS, identity systems, VPN/remote access, airport/airline shared services, supplier portals, and unmanaged wireless or travel systems.                                       |
| Third-party considerations | Require incident notifications, evidence of containment, and compensating controls from vendors handling passenger, crew, maintenance, aerospace engineering, or airport operations data. |
| Defender actions           | Segment critical operational systems, validate backups/manual procedures, tighten MFA, monitor supplier access, and rehearse service degradation playbooks.                               |

Aviation and aerospace defenders should prioritize dependencies that can interrupt check-in, boarding, dispatch, maintenance release, safety-adjacent business processes, or sensitive defense/aerospace supplier data flows. The report does not assert compromise of flight-safety systems unless explicitly stated by cited sources.

## 6. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures

| Phase                   | Observed or plausible behavior                                                                 | Defensive implication                                                    |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Initial access          | phishing, exposed services, stolen credentials, supplier access, or malicious infrastructure   | Validate controls at exposed services and identity boundaries.           |
| Execution / persistence | scripted tooling, web shells, remote management tools, OAuth/session abuse, or malware loaders | Monitor process, script, service, and SaaS audit telemetry.              |
| Command and control     | HTTPS, direct-to-IP, cloud-hosted infrastructure, or compromised legitimate services           | Hunt DNS bypass, rare destinations, and new egress from sensitive hosts. |
| Impact / objective      | data theft, extortion, espionage, credential theft, or operational disruption                  | Align containment to crown jewels and business-critical workflows.       |

## 7. Infrastructure and Indicators

No hard IOCs were independently validated beyond the cited public reporting during this automated run. Treat the following as observable classes to hunt, not confirmed indicators.

| Observable class | Example pivot                                             |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Identity events  | MFA fatigue, new OAuth grants, impossible travel, new app |

|                     |                                                                                                  |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                     | consent, disabled alerts                                                                         |
| Endpoint events     | PowerShell/curl/wget/certutil, unsigned tools, abnormal child processes, archive creation        |
| Network events      | Rare direct-to-IP outbound, unusual TLS SNI, new remote admin destinations, data transfer spikes |
| SaaS / cloud events | New tokens, anomalous downloads, suspicious mailbox/API access, tenant-wide consent              |

## 8. Victimology and Targeting

| Dimension             | Assessment                                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sector fit            | aerospace, aviation, defense, Middle East                                                                                           |
| Likely target profile | Organizations with exposed services, high-value data, sensitive partner access, or operational dependency on third-party platforms. |
| Geographic notes      | Use cited reporting; do not infer local targeting without telemetry or sector overlap.                                              |
| Exposure drivers      | Internet-facing systems, identity sprawl, SaaS permissions, remote access, and supplier connectivity.                               |

## 9. Detection Engineering

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <pre> title: LBC Daily Hunt - Middle East Aerospace Aviation Defense Espionage Campaign Br id: lbc-daily-middle-east-aerospace-aviation-defense-espionage status: experimental description: Surfaces behaviors and observables discussed in the Lost Boys Cyber daily report. logsource:   product: windows   category: process_creation detection:   selection:     CommandLine contains:       - powershell       - curl       - wget       - certutil   condition: selection fields:   - Image   - CommandLine   - ParentImage falsepositives:   - administrative scripts and software distribution level: medium DeviceProcessEvents   where Timestamp &gt; ago(14d)   where ProcessCommandLine has "Middle" or ProcessCommandLine has "Aerospace" or ProcessCommandLine has "Aviation" or ProcessCommandLine has "Defense" or ProcessCommandLine has "Espionage"   project Timestamp, DeviceName, InitiatingProcessFileName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine, AccountName   order by Timestamp desc </pre> |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## 10. Threat Hunting

| Hunt | Goal | Data sources |
|------|------|--------------|
|------|------|--------------|

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                      |                                   |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Identity abuse review                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Surface abnormal OAuth grants, MFA changes, risky sign-ins, and app consent activity | Entra ID / Okta / SaaS audit logs |
| Suspicious tooling execution                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Find script and LOLBin use aligned with campaign behaviors                           | EDR process telemetry             |
| Egress anomaly review                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Identify rare destinations, direct-to-IP communication, or unusual data movement     | Firewall, proxy, DNS, NetFlow     |
| Third-party access review                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Confirm suppliers and managed providers are not introducing unmonitored access paths | IAM, VPN, vendor portals          |
| <pre>DeviceNetworkEvents   where Timestamp &gt; ago(14d)   where RemotePort in (443, 8443, 4307, 25, 587) or RemoteUrl has_any ("oauth", "login", "vpn", "smtp")   summarize Connections=count(), Devices=dcount(DeviceName) by RemoteUrl, RemoteIP, RemotePort, InitiatingProcessFileName   order by Connections desc</pre> |                                                                                      |                                   |

## 11. Risk Assessment

| Risk             | Rating         | Rationale                                                                    |
|------------------|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Local exposure   | Medium         | Depends on technology overlap and identity/supplier architecture.            |
| Business impact  | Medium to High | Activity may affect sensitive data, operations, or trust in shared services. |
| Detection gap    | Medium         | Many behaviors blend into normal admin, SaaS, or remote-support activity.    |
| Response urgency | High           | Daily item selected for near-term defender review.                           |

## 12. Recommended Actions

| Timeframe   | Actions                                                                                                 |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Today       | Brief SOC and asset owners, confirm exposure overlap, deploy hunts, preserve relevant logs.             |
| 24-48 hours | Review third-party access, tune detections, validate MFA/OAuth controls, and check anomalous egress.    |
| 7 days      | Convert lessons into control improvements, tabletop supplier/identity scenarios, and update watchlists. |

## 13. References

- [1] The Record Iranian campaign report — <https://therecord.media/iran-cyber-espionage-campaign-targeting-middle-east-defense-aerospace> — Reports aerospace, aviation, and defense targeting in the Middle East.
- [2] CISA Iran cyber threat overview — <https://www.cisa.gov/topics/cyber-threats-and-advisories/advanced-persistent-threats/iran> — Government context for Iran-linked cyber activity.
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